

YOUR KIDS NEED YOU NOW

Adults thrive on attention. We bring sales in over plan to get the boss's attention. We drive a long luxury car to get the club members' attention. We plan a charity raffle to get your neighbors' attention. We fill our lives with games to get the others to notice and admire us. If our games fail, we can even *ask* our spouse or close friends for attention and feel fairly certain we'll get it.

Not so with kids. They thrive on attention too, especially from their parents. But their games are often too naïve, their behavior too transparent, to get them much rich attention. They may paint their faces, for example, or try to embarrass you by roller skating in the nude through an intimate dinner party, rather than come out and tell Mom or Dad that they want some of their time. Sometimes kids who need their parents' attention do get the message across. But even then, parents can seldom devote the huge amounts of time their youngsters seem to require. By the time he's a teenager, Alex may get into fights, rob cars, drop out of school, or do drugs in a desperate, unconscious effort to get attention.

Some parents try to give their kids quality time, a relatively new idea that means they spend less but more-focused time with the kids. Unfortunately, in too many cases parents who say they spend quality time give their kids little or no time at all. And when they try to spend quality time, they face a tough task. According to Alison Clarke-Stewart of the University of Chicago, during quality time, dads are especially "warm, loving, nonrejecting, . . . stimulating and enriching." That's a pretty tall order, not only for Dad but for Alex and Monica as well. And too much so-called quality time can overload. Kids probably need quiet time with Mom and Dad as much as they need quality time.

But with today's pressures, most parents have little time for their kids—quality or otherwise. Last summer in San Francisco a friend invited Vicki and me to watch his 7-year-old son's first-ever baseball game. It turned out to be quite an